The Legend of Spud Murphy

By Eoin Colfer

(Will and Marty are rough housing, loudly playing pirates or cowboys or superheroes in an improv format until DAD puts a stop to it)

DAD: **(Chapter 1)** This is a madhouse.

WILL: And he's the chief lunatic. *(pointing at Marty)*

MARTY: I'm not the one talking to dolls!

WILL: Action Man is not a doll.

DAD: *(through gritted teeth)* Quiet! There must be something we can find for you to do during the summer. Something to get you out of the house.

MOM: What about the library? *(Will and/or Marty horrified expression)*

DAD: Reading! It's perfect. How can you cause trouble reading a book?

MOM: Yes, of course, it's educational too.

MARTY: Don't make us join the library. It's too dangerous!

DAD: Dangerous? How could a library be dangerous?

MARTY: *(whispering)* It's not the library. It's the librarian.

MOM: Mrs. Murphy? She's a lovely old lady.

WILL: She's not a lovely old lady. She hates kids and she used to be a spy in the army. Tracking kids from enemy countries!

INTRODUCTION

The name Spud Murphy strikes fear into the hearts of children everywhere. Grown-ups think she's a kindly old librarian, but kids know the truth. They've heard all about the gas-powered spud gun she keeps hidden under her desk. Make so much as a sound in Spud's library, and you could get spudded with soggy potatoes. Laugh out loud, and you may never be seen again.

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MOM: I've heard enough. You two are going to the library for the afternoon and that's it. We'll make sandwiches.

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WILL: *(to audience)* Sandwiches wouldn't be much use against Spud Murphy and her gas-powered spud gun. **(Chapter 2)** Of course our little brothers thought this was hilarious. **(Chapter 1)** Having one little brother is bad enough but having three? The trouble with little brothers is that they are never blamed for anything. All Donnie, Bert and HP have to do is bat their blue eyes and let their bottom lips wobble a bit and they are forgiven for everything.

DONNIE: *(batting his eyes)* Nice knowing you!

HP: *(with a lisp)* Yeth, Nithe knowing you.

BERT: *(with a wobbly bottom lip)* Can I have your Walkman?

WILL: Do you hear them, Mom? They're teasing us already!

MOM: Oh, they don't mean it. My babies!

WILL: Mom gave them a gummi bear each and I thought that my head would pop with the unfairness of it all. **(Chapter 2)** [Later that day] Mom dropped us at the library on her way downtown.

MOM: Okay, off you go, up the steps. I'll just stay here to make sure you go inside.

WILL: *(growling quietly as the boys exit the car) (to audience)* I bet you're thinking we were a pair of gutless chickens. But that's because you think libraries are happy colorful places, where the librarians actually like children. That may be what most of them are like, but this one was different.

LITTLE BOY: *(running from the library in tears)* Don't go in there! Don't do it! I was one day late with Five Go to Smuggler's Top. Just one day. And look what she did to me! *(he runs away)*

WILL: And just like that, the boy was gone, with only a puddle of tears to prove he had ever been there. We stayed there until Mom came up the steps. We had no choice but to go inside. *(The boys enter the library and look around in fear)* The library seemed to go on forever. Row after row of wooden bookshelves.

SPUD MURPHY: *(behind the desk, she spoke with a voice like two pieces of rusted metal being rubbed together)* What do you want? *(Will and Marty quake with fear)* I said, what do you

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want? *(stamping a book vigorously with an ink stamp)(the boys approach the desk cautiously)*

WILL: *(to audience)* Spud Murphy was big. Taller than my dad, and wider than Mom and my two aunties strapped together. *(squeaking)* Mom says we have to join the library.

SPUD MURPHY: Name?

WILL: M – M – Mrs. Murphy?

SPUD MURPHY: *(Sighing)* Not my name, dummy. Your names.

WILL: *(shouting like an army cadet)* William and Martin Woodman! *(to audience)* We surrendered our name and our address was next. Now Spud knew where we lived.

SPUD MURPHY: *(fills in the library cards)* Pink cards *(handing them to the boys)* Pink means you stay in the Junior section. *(she leads them to a small section of the library . . . pointing)* That is the Junior Section.

WILL: A single bookshelf with four rows of books. On the ground -- a small patch of carpet.

SPUD MURPHY: Do not set foot off that carpet until you leave. Whatever boyish idea enters your head, ignore it. Stay on the carpet or there will be trouble. *(she bends over until her eyes are level with the boys)* Is that understood? *(she returns to her desk)*

MARTY: *(in library voices)* **(Chapter 3)** What exactly did she mean? [Does] trouble mean a strict talking-to? Or [does] trouble mean being suspended by your fingernails over a pit of alligators? I need to know how much I can get away with!

WILL: I don't need to know. I'll just sit here and pretend to read.

MARTY: No wonder Action Man is your only friend. I am an actual hero type. I am prepared to take risks! *(Marty checks to see if Spud can see him)* She can't even see us. We can do whatever we want!

WILL: What are you going to do?

MARTY: I'm going to switch a few books. The best way to mess with a librarian is too put things back in the wrong place. By the time she finds out, we'll be home watching cartoons. (Marty sneaks off the carpet and begins switching books)

WILL: *(to audience)* He switched almost every single book in the section. Mysteries with

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romance, adventure with bird-watching! Suddenly a shadow fell across my brother. *(Spud Murphy looms behind Marty)* It was Spud.

SPUD MURPHY: I knew it! *(Marty squeaks like a kitten)* I can always tell a troublemaker. I took one look at you Martin Woodman and I knew you'd be off that carpet before I was back at my desk.

MARTY: I'm sorry, Spu – Mrs. Murphy. I'll never leave the carpet again.

SPUD MURPHY: Too late for that. Since you're already off the carpet, you can fix the damage you've done, and maybe I won't tell your mother how you set off the fire alarms.

MARTY: But . . . I didn't!

SPUD MURPHY: ***I*** know you didn't. And I'm sure your mother will believe that. Unless, of course, you've been in trouble before.

WILL: *(to audience)* He'd met his match. Two hours and fourteen paper cuts later, Mom was outside, waiting in the car. We were almost safe . . .

MARTY: That wasn't so bad. I've had teachers meaner than her! *(Marty stops at the exit and turns to make a beeline for Spud's desk)* Excuse me, Mrs. Murphy. You wouldn't ***really*** say I set off the alarms, would you?

SPUD MURPHY: Oh, wouldn't I? *(She opens her desk and speaks sweetly)* **(Pg 84)** Stand in front of my desk. I have something for you. **(Chapter 3)**

WILL: **(Pg 85)** Oh no! The gas-powered spud gun!

SPUD MURPHY: You're going to get what you deserve. Go on, in front of my desk. **(Chapter 3)** I have a collection of stamps here. One came in last week you might like. It's in the shape of a pirate flag. A lot of the boys like me to stamp it onto their forearms, like a temporary tattoo. . . But maybe you're too young.

MARTY: No, I'd love that *(already rolling up his sleeve)* Wait until the guys at the swimming pool see this!

SPUD MURPHY: Are you sure, Martin? *(Spud inks the stamp)* This won't wash off for a couple of weeks.

MARTY: I'm sure. Stamp away.

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SPUD MURPHY: *(smiling widely)* Okay then. Keep still. *(she rolls the stamp on Marty forearm)*

MARTY: *(leaning over to read it, he wails)* I LOVE BARBIE!

SPUD MURPHY: Oops. Wrong stamp. Sorry about that. *(a glare)* One more thing. Any more of your little games and I get nasty. There are worse things in this desk than rubber stamps. *(she brings out her potato shooter and cocks it with a hiss)* Enjoy swimming *(she laughs as the boys run for the door)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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